Walking Through the Gospel Timeline

The verses behind the chart, and what they mean

WHAT THIS GUIDE IS

The Gospel Timeline shows the whole story of a Christian's life on one page, from before you were born to the day you see Jesus face to face. This guide walks through that chart from left to right, one stop at a time. At each stop you'll find the Bible verses behind it, printed in full, with short notes to help you see what each verse is saying and why it's there.

HOW TO USE IT

- **Keep the chart beside you.** Each stop begins with a small strip of the timeline. The red circle shows where you are.
- **Read the verses slowly.** They matter more than the notes. The notes are there to help you see what's in the verse.
- **Alone or with someone.** Read it on your own, or go through it with a mentor in five sittings, one part at a time. At the back you'll find the three tenses of salvation, a list of key words and an index of every verse.

READING THE VERSES

bold	Key words that connect the verse to that part of the chart.	[God]	Added to make clear who is speaking or who is meant. Not part of the Bible text.
…	The verse starts or ends in the middle of a sentence.	23	Verse number.

THE FIVE PARTS

1	**Before Christ** · Chosen before time, sinful at birth, dead in sin
2	**Coming to Christ** · The gospel heard, the Spirit at work, turning to Jesus
3	**The cross: once for all** · What God does the moment you believe
4	**Growing in Christ** · The everyday life of a Christian
5	**Death and the life to come** · Going home, and the day Christ returns

✦ The whole timeline in one verse

the verse at the top of the chart

Romans 8:30

> [30] And those he [God] **predestined**, he also **called**; those he called, he also **justified**; those he justified, he also **glorified**.

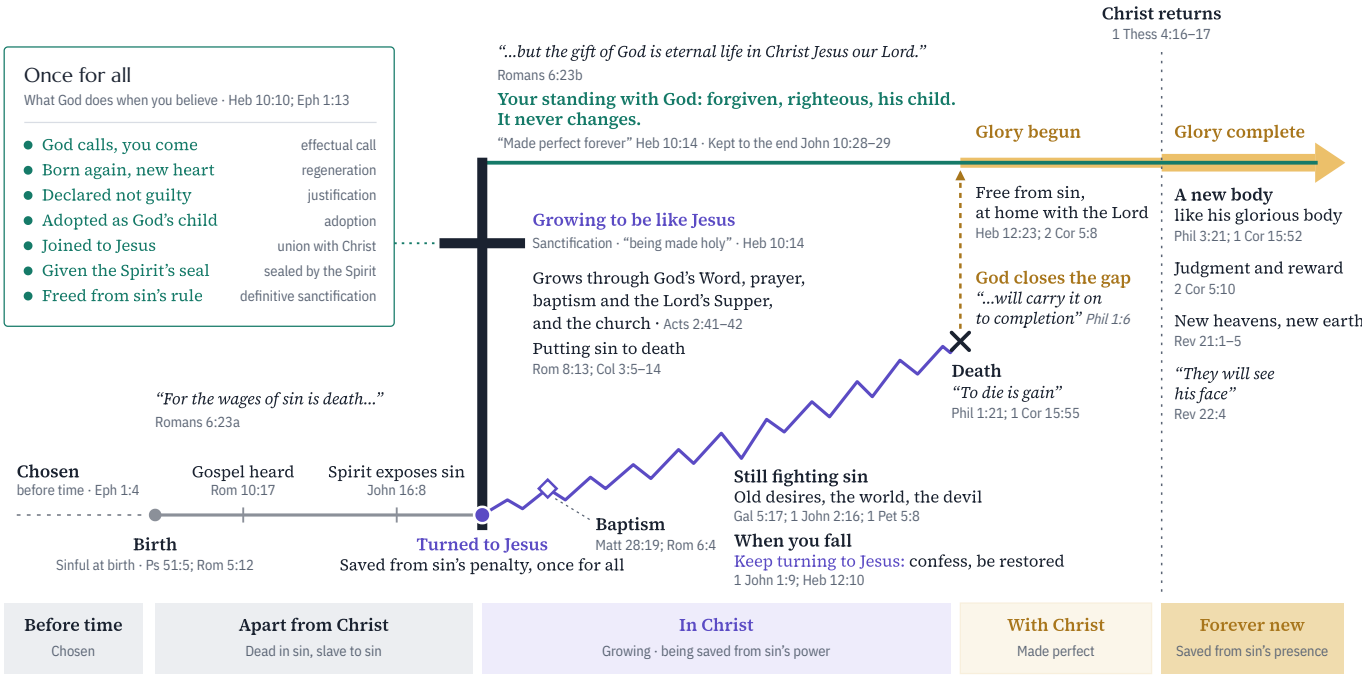
WHAT TO NOTICE Follow the four bold words across the chart:

- **Predestined** (decided beforehand)**:** the far left, "Chosen before time" (Part 1).
- **Called:** the gospel heard, and God drawing you to himself (Parts 2 and 3).
- **Justified:** the cross, where God declares you not guilty (Part 3).
- **Glorified:** the gold at the far right (Part 5).

No one drops out of the chain. Everyone God predestined, he calls; everyone he calls, he justifies; everyone he justifies, he glorifies. And look at the last word: Paul writes "glorified" as if it has already happened. God's future is so sure that he can speak of it as done.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

How to read the chart



The Gospel Timeline, page 1

WHAT THE LINES AND MARKS MEAN

Gray line: dead in sin. It's flat because there's no spiritual life until God gives it. It's dotted at the far left, before you were born.

The cross: the moment you turned to Jesus. Everything changes here. The gray line ends and two new lines begin.

Teal line: your standing with God. Set once for all at the cross. It never rises or falls.

Violet line: your growth. It climbs with real ups and downs, but over a lifetime it heads up.

X: death. The growth line stops here, still short of the teal line. No one becomes fully like Jesus in this life.

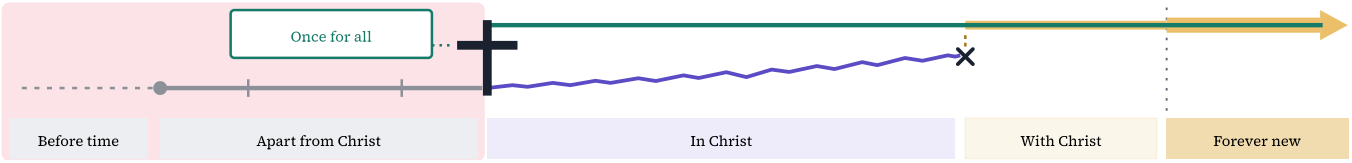
Dashed gold arrow: God closes the gap. At death, God finishes his work in you and makes your soul perfect.

Gold band: glory. Thin at death, when your soul is with the Lord. Full at Christ's return, when body and soul are together again and everything is made new.

Bands along the bottom: the five seasons. Before time, apart from Christ, in Christ, with Christ, forever new.

PART 1

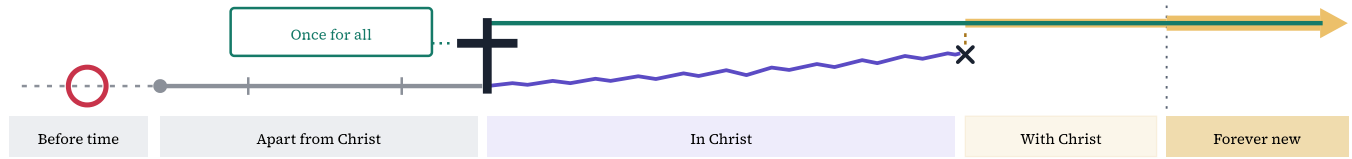
Before Christ



Before you ever thought about God, he was thinking about you. But you were also born into a world broken by sin, and born a sinner yourself. This part covers the left side of the chart: the dotted line before birth, and the flat gray line after it.

1 Chosen before time

election



ON THE CHART The dotted gray line at the far left. It's dotted because you didn't exist yet, but God's plan for you already did.

IN PLAIN WORDS Before God made the world, he chose to save a people for himself, in Christ. Your salvation didn't start with your decision. It started with his. That doesn't make your faith any less real. It means your faith rests on something older and stronger than you.

Ephesians 1:4

> [4] For he [God] **chose us** in him [Christ] **before the creation of the world** to be **holy and blameless in his sight**. …

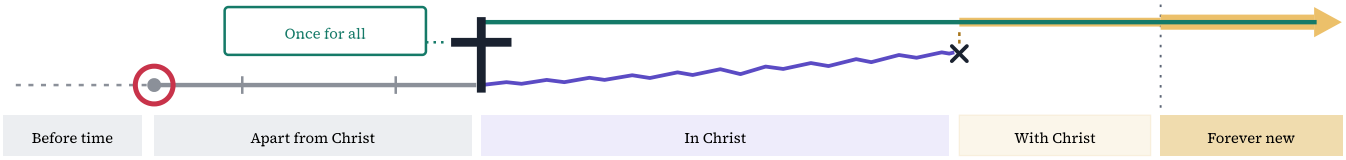
WHAT TO NOTICE

- **"Before the creation of the world."** God chose before you existed, before you had done anything good or bad. So his choice can't depend on anything you did.
- **"In him."** God chose us in Christ. You never have to look for God's choice somewhere apart from Jesus. Look to Jesus.
- **"To be holy and blameless."** God chose us for a purpose. His goal is the far right end of the chart, when we stand before him without any fault.

Word to know: election. God's choice, made before time, to save his people in Christ. It's the "predestined" of Romans 8:30.

2 Sinful at birth

a sinful nature



ON THE CHART The solid gray dot labeled “Birth.” Your life on earth begins here, and the gray line begins with it.

IN PLAIN WORDS We aren’t born neutral and then become sinners the first time we do something wrong. We’re born with hearts already turned away from God. That’s why the line is gray from the start.

Psalm 51:5

> [5] Surely **I was sinful at birth**,
> **sinful from the time my mother conceived me**.

WHAT THIS ADDS **A personal confession.** King David wrote this psalm after his sin with Bathsheba; the heading above the psalm tells the story. Looking at what he had done, David saw that it went all the way back. His sin wasn’t a one-time slip. It came from a heart that was sinful from the very beginning. This is a prayer, and anyone can pray it.

Romans 5:12

> [12] Therefore, just as **sin entered the world through one man** [Adam], and **death through sin**, and in this way **death came to all people, because all sinned**— …

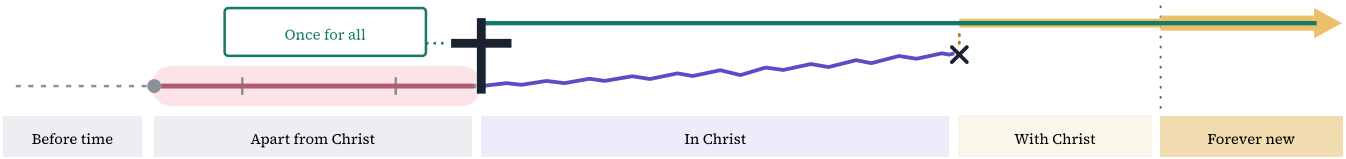
WHAT THIS ADDS **The explanation.** Paul goes back to the beginning. Sin came into the world through Adam (he names him in verse 14), and death came with it. Every person since has been born into Adam’s family and shares his condition. “All sinned”: there are no exceptions.

HOW THEY FIT TOGETHER Psalm 51 is the view from inside one heart: “I was sinful at birth.” Romans 5 is the view of the whole human race: “all sinned.” Together they show that our problem isn’t only what we do; it’s who we are from birth. That’s why we need more than a better life. We need a new one (Part 3).

Word to know: sin. Turning away from God and his ways in what we think, say and do. It’s also the condition of a heart that is turned away from him.

3 Dead in sin

apart from Christ



ON THE CHART The flat gray line from birth to the cross, and the band under it: “Apart from Christ: dead in sin, slave to sin.” Above it is the first half of a verse: “For the wages of sin is death…”

IN PLAIN WORDS A flatline is what a heart monitor shows when there’s no life. Apart from Christ, a person can be kind, religious and successful and still be spiritually dead toward God. And a dead person can’t make themselves alive. Life has to come from outside.

Ephesians 2:1

> [1] As for you, **you were dead in your transgressions and sins**, …

WHAT THIS ADDS **The flatline.** Paul doesn't say sick or weak. He says dead. A sick person can take medicine; a dead person needs a miracle. (Keep reading to verses 4–5 and you'll find the miracle: God "made us alive with Christ.")

Romans 6:17

> [17] But thanks be to God that, though **you used to be slaves to sin**, you have come to obey from your heart the pattern of teaching that has now claimed your allegiance.

WHAT THIS ADDS **The chains.** Apart from Christ, sin isn't only something we do; it's a master we serve. But notice the words "used to be." For a Christian, that's in the past (Part 3, "Freed from sin's rule").

Romans 6:23

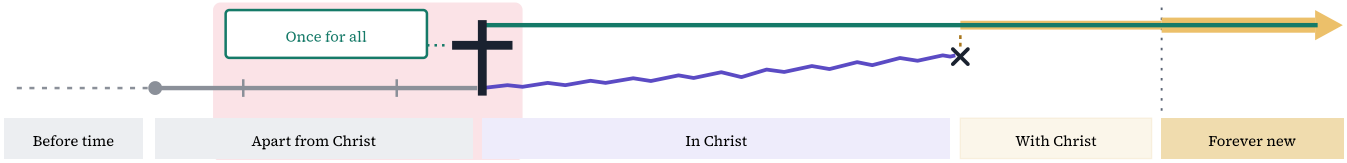
> [23] **For the wages of sin is death**, but the gift of God is eternal life in Christ Jesus our Lord.

WHAT THIS ADDS **Where the line leads.** Wages are what you earn. Sin pays out in death: the death of the body and, worse, being cut off from God forever. The chart splits this verse on purpose. The first half sits over the gray line, and the second half sits over the cross. We'll come back to it at the cross (stop 6).

HOW THEY FIT TOGETHER Three pictures of life apart from Christ: **dead** (Ephesians 2:1), **enslaved** (Romans 6:17), and **headed for death** (Romans 6:23). Each one shows we can't fix this ourselves. The dead can't raise themselves, slaves can't buy their own freedom, and no one can pay off these wages. That's why the rest of the chart is about God stepping in.

PART 2

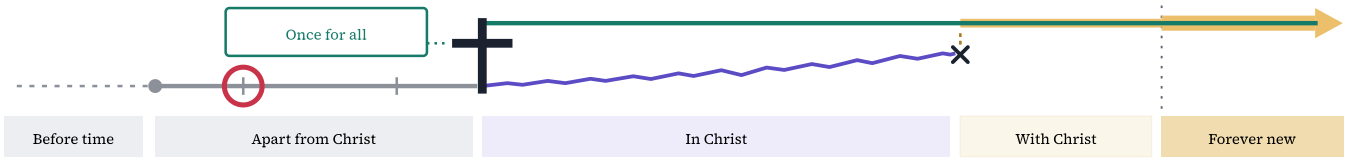
Coming to Christ



Two small marks sit on the gray line just before the cross: “Gospel heard” and “Spirit exposes sin.” They’re still on the flatline, because hearing the gospel and feeling guilty aren’t yet new life. But they’re how God brings a person to the cross.

4 Gospel heard

the good news



ON THE CHART The first small mark on the gray line: “Gospel heard.”

IN PLAIN WORDS God brings people to faith through a message: the good news about Jesus. Someone tells it, and someone hears it. That’s why Christians share the gospel, and why the church preaches it.

Romans 10:17

> [17] Consequently, **faith comes from hearing the message**, and the message is heard through **the word about Christ**.

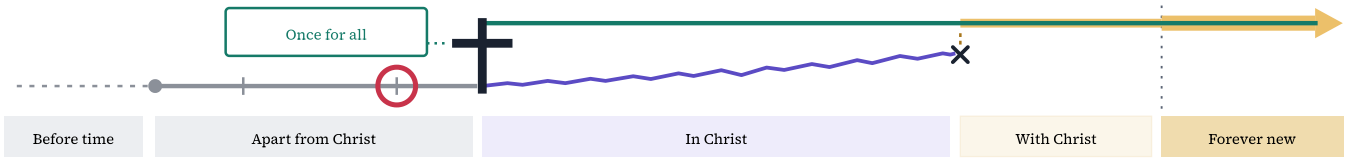
WHAT TO NOTICE

- **“Consequently”** points back to verses 14–15. Paul has just asked how people can believe in someone they’ve never heard of, and how they can hear unless someone tells them.
- **“Faith comes from hearing.”** Faith doesn’t appear out of nowhere. It’s a response to something God has said.
- **“The word about Christ.”** The message is about Jesus: who he is and what he did. Faith isn’t believing in yourself, or in believing. It’s trusting him.

Word to know: gospel. “Good news.” The message that Jesus, the Son of God, died for our sins and rose again, and that everyone who trusts him is forgiven and made new.

5 Spirit exposes sin

conviction



ON THE CHART The second small mark on the gray line: "Spirit exposes sin."

IN PLAIN WORDS Hearing the gospel isn't enough by itself. The Holy Spirit makes it personal. He shows you that your sin is real, that it's yours, and that you need Jesus. That uncomfortable feeling isn't God pushing you away. It's God drawing you near.

John 16:8

> [8] When he [the Holy Spirit] comes, **he will prove the world to be in the wrong about sin** and righteousness and judgment: ...

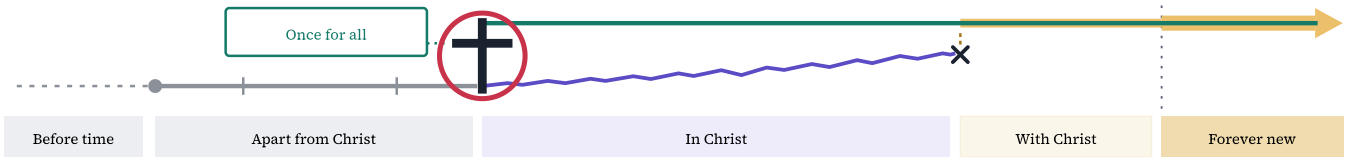
WHAT TO NOTICE

- **Who is speaking.** Jesus, the night before he died. In verse 7 he calls the Spirit "the Advocate" and promises to send him.
- **"Prove ... to be in the wrong."** Like a lawyer making a case. The Spirit makes the case against us so clearly that we stop arguing.
- **"About sin."** The next verse explains: "because people do not believe in me." The deepest sin the Spirit exposes isn't a list of bad deeds. It's not trusting Jesus.
- **"The world."** Jesus is describing the Spirit's work in the world at large. Everyone who comes to faith experiences that same work personally.

Word to know: conviction. The Holy Spirit's work of showing you your sin and your need for Jesus.

6 Turned to Jesus

repentance and faith



ON THE CHART The cross. The gray line stops, and two new lines begin: the teal line at the top (your standing) and the violet line at the bottom (your growth). Under the cross: "Turned to Jesus. Saved from sin's penalty, once for all."

IN PLAIN WORDS This is the turning point of the whole chart. Turning to Jesus has two sides: turning away from sin (repentance) and trusting Jesus (faith). They're two sides of one turn: you can't turn toward Jesus without turning away from something. And in that moment, God gives a gift you could never earn.

Acts 20:21

> [21] I [Paul] have declared to both Jews and Greeks that **they must turn to God in repentance and have faith in our Lord Jesus**.

WHAT THIS ADDS **The response.** Paul is summing up years of preaching for the church leaders from Ephesus. His whole message came down to two things: repentance toward God and faith in Jesus. “Both Jews and Greeks” means everyone. It’s the same way in for religious people and non-religious people.

Romans 6:23

> [23] For the wages of sin is death, but **the gift of God is eternal life in Christ Jesus our Lord**.

WHAT THIS ADDS **The gift.** Here’s the other half of the verse from stop 3. Notice the contrast. Wages are earned; a gift is received. Death is what we earned. Eternal life is what God gives, and it’s found only “in Christ Jesus.”

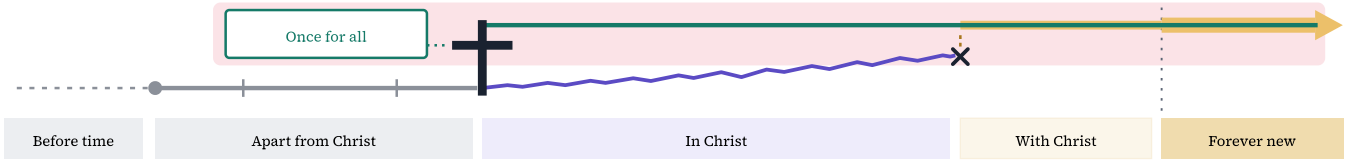
HOW THEY FIT TOGETHER Acts 20:21 tells you what to do: turn and trust. Romans 6:23 tells you what you receive: a gift. Faith doesn’t earn the gift; it receives it, like an open hand. That’s why the cross rises from the gray line up to the teal line. God reaches down into death and gives life.

Words to know: repentance and faith. *Repentance* is turning away from sin and toward God, a change of mind that shows up in a changed life. *Faith* is trusting Jesus, relying on him and not on yourself to make you right with God.

What happens in that moment? Part 3 opens the box on the chart labeled “Once for all.”

PART 3

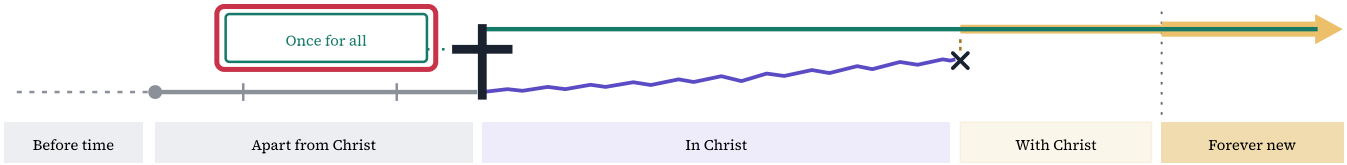
The cross: once for all



At the cross the gray line stops and two new lines begin. But first the chart opens a box: “Once for all.” It lists seven things God does the moment you believe. None of them grows or shrinks over time, and none can be undone. That’s why the box connects to the teal line of your standing, not the violet line of your growth.

7 Once for all

what God does when you believe



ON THE CHART The box at the top left, outlined in teal, with a dotted line to the cross. Its subtitle: “What God does when you believe.”

IN PLAIN WORDS Two moments meet in this box. One is the cross, where Jesus died once for all time. The other is the moment you believed, when what he did there became yours. Jesus’ work was finished long ago. The Holy Spirit gives it to you when you believe.

Hebrews 10:10

> [10] And by that will [God’s will], **we have been made holy through the sacrifice of the body of Jesus Christ once for all**.

WHAT THIS ADDS **When the work was done: at the cross.** “Once for all” describes Jesus’ sacrifice. It never needs to be repeated or added to. The next verse makes the contrast: the old priests offered sacrifices “again and again.” “Made holy” here means set apart as God’s own. It’s a finished fact, and it’s different from the daily growth in holiness on the violet line (Part 4).

Ephesians 1:13

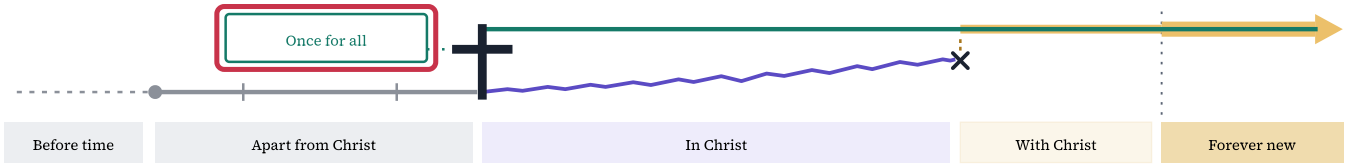
> [13] And you also were **included in Christ** when you heard the message of truth, the gospel of your salvation. **When you believed**, you were marked in him with a seal, the promised Holy Spirit, …

WHAT THIS ADDS **When it became yours: when you believed.** Notice the order: you heard, you believed, you were sealed. It’s the same order as the chart: gospel heard (stop 4), turned to Jesus (stop 6), once for all (this box).

HOW THEY FIT TOGETHER Hebrews 10:10 tells you when the work was done: at the cross. Ephesians 1:13 tells you when it became yours: when you believed. Both happen once. Jesus never has to die again, and you never have to be saved again.

8 God calls, you come

effectual call



ON THE CHART The first line in the box. Page 2 of the chart adds: "God draws you through the gospel, and he is faithful to keep you firm to the end."

IN PLAIN WORDS Many people hear the gospel (stop 4). But when God calls someone to himself, the call works: that person comes. That's why it's called the "effectual" call, meaning the call that takes effect. And the God who calls you will finish what he started.

> **Romans 8:30** is printed on page 1. Look again at the middle of the chain: "those he called, he also justified." Everyone God calls in this way reaches the next step. The call doesn't fail.

1 Corinthians 1:8–9

> [8] He will also **keep you firm to the end**, so that you will be **blameless on the day of our Lord Jesus Christ**.
> [9] **God is faithful, who has called you** into fellowship with his Son, Jesus Christ our Lord.

WHAT TO NOTICE

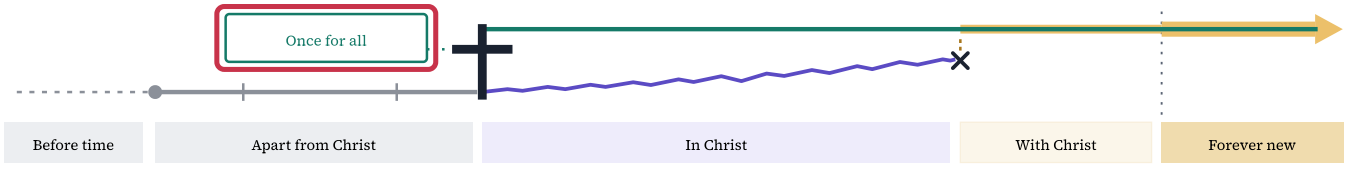
- **"To the end."** God's call has a destination: standing blameless when Christ returns, at the far right of the chart.
- **"God is faithful."** Verse 9 shows what the promise rests on: God's faithfulness, not yours.
- **"Into fellowship with his Son."** God calls you into a relationship with Jesus, not only into a religion.

HOW THEY FIT TOGETHER Romans 8:30 shows where God's call leads: on to justified and glorified. 1 Corinthians 1:8–9 shows why it gets there: the God who called you is faithful to keep you.

Word to know: effectual call. God's call through the gospel that actually brings a person to faith in Jesus.

9 Born again, new heart

regeneration



ON THE CHART The second line in the box. Page 2 adds: "God gives new life to a dead heart. You can't be unborn."

IN PLAIN WORDS Remember the flatline (stop 3): the dead can't make themselves alive. Being born again is God giving spiritual life to a dead heart. You didn't cause your first birth, and you don't cause this one. And just as you can't be unborn, this new birth can't be undone.

John 3:3–8

> [3] Jesus replied, “Very truly I tell you, **no one can see the kingdom of God unless they are born again**.” [4] “How can someone be born when they are old?” Nicodemus asked. “Surely they cannot enter a second time into their mother’s womb to be born!” [5] Jesus answered, “Very truly I tell you, no one can enter the kingdom of God unless they are **born of water and the Spirit**. [6] Flesh gives birth to flesh, but **the Spirit gives birth to spirit**. [7] You should not be surprised at my saying, ‘**You must be born again**.’ [8] The wind blows wherever it pleases. You hear its sound, but you cannot tell where it comes from or where it is going. **So it is with everyone born of the Spirit**.”

WHAT TO NOTICE

- **Who Jesus is talking to.** Nicodemus, a respected religious leader (verse 1). If anyone could get in by being good, it was him. Jesus tells even him that he needs a new birth.
- **Nicodemus is confused (verse 4).** He pictures a second physical birth. Jesus means a birth “of the Spirit.”
- **“Water and the Spirit” (verse 5).** Many readers hear an echo of Ezekiel 36:25–27, where God promises to wash his people clean, give them a new heart and put his Spirit in them. That’s the “new heart” on the chart.
- **“The wind blows” (verse 8).** You can’t control the wind or see it, but you can see what it does. The Spirit’s work is like that. You can’t schedule it, but you can see it in a changed life.

1 Peter 1:23

> [23] For **you have been born again**, **not of perishable seed, but of imperishable**, through the living and enduring word of God.

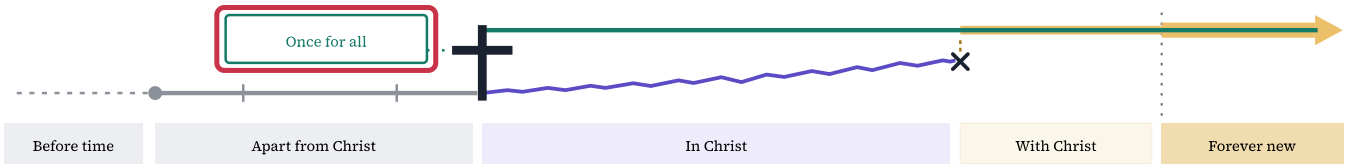
WHAT THIS ADDS **Why it can’t be undone.** Perishable seed is the kind that dies. Your new life came from seed that can’t die. And notice how it came: “through the word of God.” God uses the gospel message (stop 4) to give new birth.

HOW THEY FIT TOGETHER John 3 says you must be born again, and only the Spirit can do it. 1 Peter 1 says the life he gives is imperishable. That’s why the chart says, “You can’t be unborn.”

Word to know: regeneration. God’s work of giving new spiritual life to a person. It’s another word for being born again.

10 Declared not guilty

justification



ON THE CHART The third line in the box. Page 2 adds: “God declares you righteous because of Jesus. No charge can ever stand against you.”

IN PLAIN WORDS Justification is a courtroom word. It isn’t God making you a better person; that’s growth (Part 4). It’s God’s verdict about you: not guilty, and righteous in his sight. That verdict rests on what Jesus did, not on what you do, so it never changes.

Romans 8:1

> [1] Therefore, there is **now no condemnation** for those who are **in Christ Jesus**, …

WHAT THIS ADDS **The verdict.** "Now," not someday. "No condemnation," not less condemnation. And it's for everyone who is "in Christ Jesus" (stop 12).

Romans 8:33–34

> [33] **Who will bring any charge against those whom God has chosen? It is God who justifies.** [34] Who then is the one who condemns? **No one.** Christ Jesus who died—more than that, who was raised to life—is at the right hand of God and is also **interceding for us**.

WHAT THIS ADDS **No one can overturn it.** Paul pictures a courtroom and asks who could accuse you. The judge himself has declared you righteous. And Jesus, who died and rose again, speaks up for you. Notice "those whom God has chosen." The verdict goes back to stop 1.

2 Corinthians 5:21

> [21] God made him [Christ] **who had no sin to be sin for us**, so that in him **we might become the righteousness of God**.

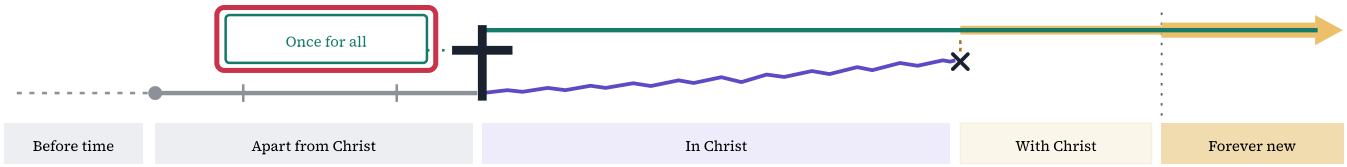
WHAT THIS ADDS **Why the verdict is fair.** It's an exchange. Jesus took our sin, and we receive his righteousness. God didn't ignore our sin. It was paid for in full.

HOW THEY FIT TOGETHER Romans 8:1 gives the verdict: no condemnation. Romans 8:33–34 shows that no one can overturn it. 2 Corinthians 5:21 shows why it's just: Jesus took our place.

Word to know: justification. God declaring a sinner righteous, not because of anything they have done, but because of what Jesus did. It's received by faith.

11 Adopted as God's child

adoption



ON THE CHART The fourth line in the box. Page 2 adds: "You belong to God's family as his child and heir, forever."

IN PLAIN WORDS Justification happens in the courtroom; adoption happens in the family. God doesn't only declare you not guilty and send you on your way. He brings you home as his child, with every right of a child in his family.

Galatians 4:4–7

> [4] But when the set time had fully come, God sent his Son, born of a woman, born under the law, [5] to redeem those under the law, **that we might receive adoption to sonship**. [6] Because you are his sons, God sent the Spirit of his Son into our hearts, the Spirit who calls out, "**Abba, Father**." [7] So **you are no longer a slave, but God's child**; and since you are his child, God has made you also an **heir**.

WHAT TO NOTICE

- **Why Jesus came (verses 4–5).** He came "to redeem … that we might receive adoption." Being brought into God's family is one of the reasons for the cross.
- **"Adoption to sonship."** In Paul's world, sons received the inheritance. The phrase means full heir status, for men and women alike. Verse 7 says it plainly: "God's child."
- **"Abba."** An Aramaic word a child would use for a father, close and trusting. The Spirit teaches you to pray that way.
- **"No longer a slave."** This looks back to stop 3. You were a slave to sin. Now you're a child in the house.

Romans 8:15–17

> [15] The Spirit you received **does not make you slaves, so that you live in fear again**; rather, the Spirit you received brought about your **adoption to sonship**. And by him we cry, "Abba, Father." [16] **The Spirit himself testifies with our spirit that we are God's children.** [17] Now if we are children, then we are heirs—**heirs of God and co-heirs with Christ**, if indeed we share in his sufferings in order that we may also **share in his glory**.

WHAT TO NOTICE

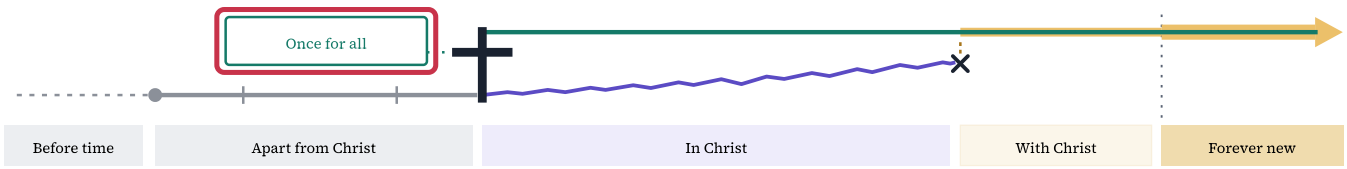
- **"Not … in fear."** A slave lives afraid of being sent away. A child doesn't.
- **"The Spirit himself testifies."** God doesn't leave you guessing whether you belong. His Spirit in you confirms it.
- **"Co-heirs with Christ."** You share in what Jesus inherits.
- **"If indeed we share in his sufferings."** God's children walk the same road as his Son: suffering now, glory later, at the right end of the chart.

HOW THEY FIT TOGETHER Galatians shows that adoption is what Jesus came to accomplish. Romans shows how you know it's yours: the Spirit tells you, and he teaches you to call God "Father." Both passages end the same way, with you as an heir, looking ahead to glory.

Word to know: adoption. God's act of making you his child, with all the rights of a son or daughter in his family.

12 Joined to Jesus

union with Christ



ON THE CHART The fifth line in the box. Page 2 adds: "You are in Christ, and nothing can separate you from his love."

IN PLAIN WORDS "In Christ" may be the two most important words in the New Testament letters. Every gift in this box is yours because you are joined to Jesus. What is true of him becomes true of you. His death counts as your death to sin, and his risen life becomes your new life.

Romans 6:3–5

> [3] Or don't you know that all of us who were **baptized into Christ Jesus were baptized into his death**? [4] We were therefore **buried with him** through baptism into death in order that, just as Christ was raised from the dead through the glory of the Father, **we too may live a new life**. [5] For if we have been **united with him in a death like his**, we will certainly also be **united with him in a resurrection like his**.

WHAT THIS ADDS **How you are joined.** Baptism pictures it (more on baptism in Part 4). Going under the water is being buried with him. Coming up is rising to a new life. And "will certainly" makes the end sure: one day you will be raised like him, at the far right of the chart.

Romans 8:38–39

> [38] For I [Paul] am convinced that **neither death nor life**, neither angels nor demons, neither the present nor the future, nor any powers, [39] neither height nor depth, **nor anything else in all creation, will be able to separate us from the love of God that is in Christ Jesus our Lord**.

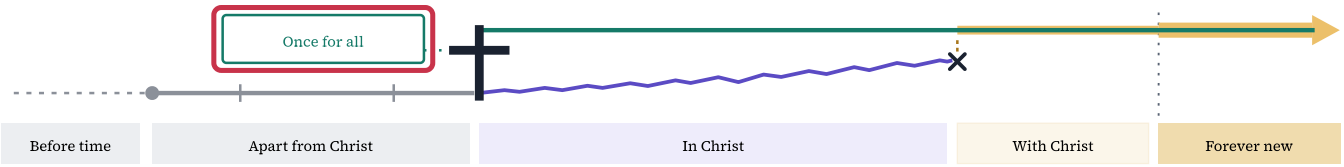
WHAT THIS ADDS **How long you are joined.** Paul lists everything he can think of: death, spiritual powers, time and space. Then he adds "anything else in all creation" to cover the rest. And notice where God's love is: "in Christ Jesus." Joined to him, you are inside that love.

HOW THEY FIT TOGETHER Romans 6 shows how you are joined: with Jesus in his death and his resurrection. Romans 8 shows how long: nothing can pull you apart.

Word to know: union with Christ. Being joined to Jesus by faith, so that what is true of him becomes true of you.

13 Given the Spirit's seal

sealed by the Spirit



ON THE CHART The sixth line in the box. Page 2 adds: "The Spirit lives in you as God's guarantee until the day of redemption."

IN PLAIN WORDS When you believed, God gave you his Holy Spirit to live in you. The Spirit is like a seal that marks you as God's own, and like a down payment that guarantees the rest is coming.

Ephesians 1:13–14

> [13] And you also were included in Christ when you heard the message of truth, the gospel of your salvation. When you believed, you were **marked in him with a seal, the promised Holy Spirit**, [14] who is **a deposit guaranteeing our inheritance** until the redemption of those who are **God's possession**—to the praise of his glory.

WHAT TO NOTICE

- **"A seal."** In the ancient world, a seal marked who owned something and protected what was inside. The Spirit marks you as "God's possession."
- **"A deposit."** A first payment that guarantees the full amount will follow. The Spirit in you now is a first taste of the glory to come.
- Verse 13 appeared at stop 7. Here it continues into verse 14.

Ephesians 4:30

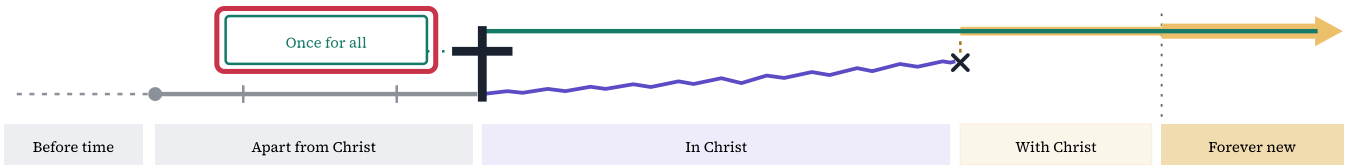
> [30] And do not grieve the Holy Spirit of God, with whom you were **sealed for the day of redemption**.

WHAT THIS ADDS **How long the seal lasts.** Even while warning about sin, Paul reminds his readers that the seal holds "for the day of redemption." That day is Christ's return, at the far right of the chart. Sin can grieve the Spirit, but it doesn't break the seal.

HOW THEY FIT TOGETHER The seal marks you as God's. The deposit guarantees that the rest is coming. And the seal lasts until the day of redemption. That's why the chart calls the Spirit God's guarantee.

14 Freed from sin's rule

definitive sanctification



ON THE CHART The last line in the box. Page 2 adds: "Sin is still present, but it is no longer your master."

IN PLAIN WORDS Holiness has a once-for-all side. At the cross, sin lost its throne in your life. It still fights, as Part 4 shows, but it no longer rules. That's why real change is possible.

Romans 6:14

> [14] For **sin shall no longer be your master**, because you are not under the law, but **under grace**.

WHAT THIS ADDS **A promise, not only a command.** Verses 12–13 tell us not to let sin reign. Verse 14 gives the reason we can obey: sin is no longer our master. Grace doesn't only forgive; it also frees.

Romans 6:18

> [18] You have been **set free from sin** and have become **slaves to righteousness**.

WHAT THIS ADDS **A new master.** Compare stop 3: "you used to be slaves to sin" (Romans 6:17). Now you serve righteousness. And notice "have been": it already happened.

1 Corinthians 6:11

> [11] And **that is what some of you were**. But **you were washed, you were sanctified, you were justified** in the name of the Lord Jesus Christ and by the Spirit of our God.

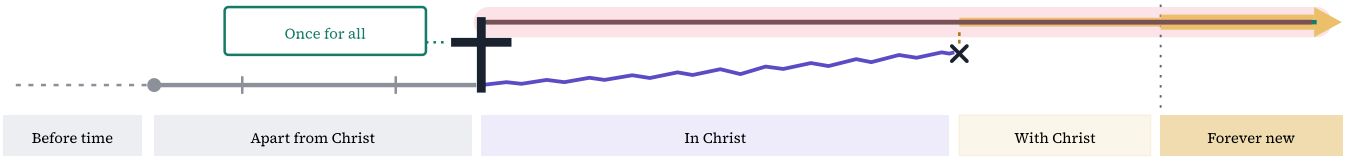
WHAT THIS ADDS **The old identity is in the past.** Paul has just listed sins (verses 9–10), and he says, "That is what some of you were." Notice that "sanctified" stands in the past tense right beside "justified." It's the once-for-all kind of holiness. Your growth in holiness (the violet line) builds on it.

HOW THEY FIT TOGETHER Romans 6:14 says sin isn't your master. Romans 6:18 says you have a new one. 1 Corinthians 6:11 says your old identity is in the past. The struggle goes on (Part 4), but you fight it from a new place.

Word to know: definitive sanctification. The once-for-all break with sin's rule when you are joined to Christ. It's different from *progressive* sanctification, the lifelong growth shown by the violet line.

15 Your standing with God

made perfect forever



ON THE CHART The teal line from the top of the cross to the far right, level the whole way. Above it: "Your standing with God: forgiven, righteous, his child. It never changes."

IN PLAIN WORDS The seven gifts in the box add up to your standing with God: forgiven, righteous, his child. The line is drawn flat because it doesn't rise on good days or fall on bad ones. It rests on what Jesus did, and that never changes.

Hebrews 10:14

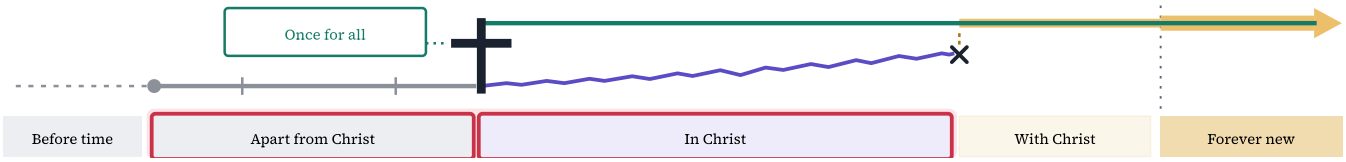
> [14] For **by one sacrifice** he [Jesus] has **made perfect forever** those who are **being made holy**.

WHAT TO NOTICE This one verse holds both lines of the chart.

- **"Made perfect forever"** is the teal line: finished and permanent.
- **"Being made holy"** is the violet line: ongoing, still in progress.
- **Look at who is made perfect forever:** people who are still being made holy. You don't have to finish growing to be fully accepted. God accepts you completely now, while he keeps working in you.
- **"By one sacrifice."** Verses 11–12 contrast the priests, who offered sacrifices "again and again," with Jesus, who offered one sacrifice and "sat down." His work is finished.

16 Two identities

who you were, and who you are



ON THE CHART The table on page 2. The left column is who you were apart from Christ. The right column is who you are in Christ.

IN PLAIN WORDS Every change in this table happened at the cross, once for all. Read across each row. Where a verse was already printed in this guide, the row points back to it.

APART FROM CHRIST	IN CHRIST
Dead in transgressions and sins Ephesians 2:1 · see stop 3	**Made alive with Christ** Ephesians 2:4–5 [4] But because of his great love for us, God, who is rich in mercy, [5] **made us alive with Christ even when we were dead in transgressions**—it is by grace you have been saved.
Slave to sin Romans 6:17 · see stop 3	**Slave to righteousness** Romans 6:18 · see stop 14
Deserving of wrath Ephesians 2:3 [3] All of us also lived among them at one time, gratifying the cravings of our flesh and following its desires and thoughts. Like the rest, **we were by nature deserving of wrath**.	**Child of God** John 1:12 [12] Yet to all who did receive him [Jesus], to those who believed in his name, he gave **the right to become children of God**— …
Old self Ephesians 4:22 [22] You were taught, with regard to your former way of life, to put off **your old self, which is being corrupted by its deceitful desires**; …	**New creation** 2 Corinthians 5:17 [17] Therefore, if anyone is in Christ, **the new creation has come: The old has gone, the new is here!**

Enemy of God → Reconciled to God

Romans 5:10

[10] For if, **while we were God's enemies**, **we were reconciled to him through the death of his Son**, how much more, having been reconciled, shall we be saved through his life!

In the dominion of darkness → In the kingdom of the Son

Colossians 1:13

[13] For he [the Father] has rescued us **from the dominion of darkness** and brought us **into the kingdom of the Son he loves**, …

Without hope and without God

Ephesians 2:12

> [12] … remember that at that time you were separate from Christ, excluded from citizenship in Israel and foreigners to the covenants of the promise, **without hope and without God in the world**.

A living hope

1 Peter 1:3

> [3] Praise be to the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ! In his great mercy he has given us **new birth into a living hope** through the resurrection of Jesus Christ from the dead, …

The wages of sin is death

Romans 6:23 · see stop 3

The gift of God is eternal life

Romans 6:23 · see stop 6

WHAT TO NOTICE

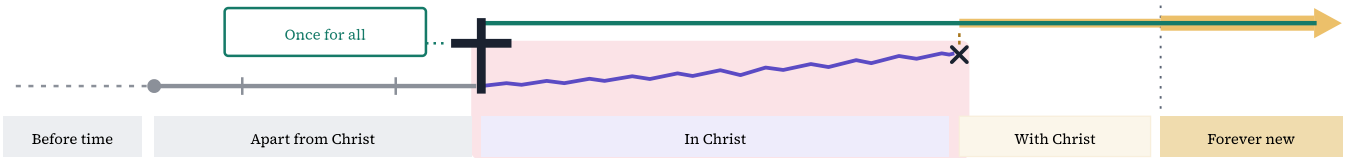
- **Some rows need only one verse.** Romans 5:10, Colossians 1:13 and Romans 6:23 each hold both sides in a single sentence. The Bible often puts the before and after side by side, because the change is that sharp.
- **"Made alive … even when we were dead."** God didn't wait for us to improve. He gave life to the dead (Ephesians 2:5).
- **"How much more" (Romans 5:10).** If God made peace with his enemies, he will surely keep his children.

HOW THEY FIT TOGETHER Your feelings may move between these two columns from day to day. Your identity doesn't. The right-hand column is who you are now. The violet line in Part 4 is about learning to live like it.

Part 4 follows the violet line: what it looks like to grow in Christ.

PART 4

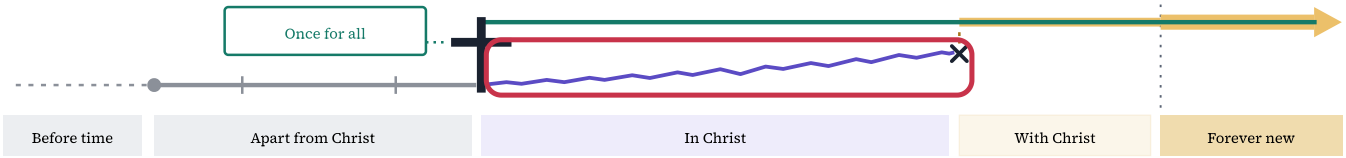
Growing in Christ



After the cross, the chart draws two lines. The teal line of your standing stays level. The violet line of your growth climbs, with real ups and downs. Part 4 follows the violet line: how God makes you more like Jesus, the tools he uses, the fight with sin that goes on, and his promise to keep you to the end. Everything in this part grows or changes over time. None of it changes your standing (stop 15).

17 Growing to be like Jesus

sanctification



ON THE CHART The violet line climbing from the cross toward the right. Its label: "Growing to be like Jesus · Sanctification · 'being made holy.'" The band along the bottom names this season "In Christ: growing, being saved from sin's power."

IN PLAIN WORDS Once you belong to God, he starts to change you. Over a lifetime you become more like Jesus in what you love, think, say and do. The line goes up and down, but over the years it heads up. Your standing is finished; your growth is a process, and you take part in it.

> **Hebrews 10:14** is printed at stop 15. Its last words, "being made holy," are this violet line.

2 Corinthians 3:18

> [18] And we all, who with unveiled faces **contemplate the Lord's glory**, **are being transformed into his image with ever-increasing glory**, which comes from **the Lord, who is the Spirit**.

WHAT THIS ADDS **Who does the changing, and how.** "Are being transformed" is ongoing, and it's done to us by the Spirit. We change by looking: as you "contemplate the Lord's glory" in his Word, you become more like the one you're looking at. And "ever-increasing glory" points ahead to the gold at the right end of the chart.

Philippians 2:12–13

> [12] Therefore, my dear friends, as you have always obeyed—not only in my presence, but now much more in my absence—**continue to work out your salvation** with fear and trembling, [13] for **it is God who works in you to will and to act** in order to fulfill his good purpose.

WHAT TO NOTICE

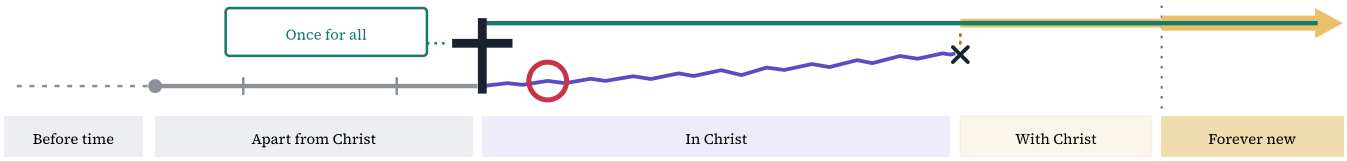
- **"Work out," not "work for."** Paul is writing to "dear friends" who already believe. You don't work to earn salvation. You live out the salvation you have.
- **"For it is God who works in you."** Your effort rests on his. He gives both the desire ("to will") and the strength ("to act").
- **"Fear and trembling."** Not fear of being thrown out, but serious, humble awe, because God himself is at work in you.

HOW THEY FIT TOGETHER 2 Corinthians 3:18 shows that the Spirit is the one changing you. Philippians 2:12–13 shows that you take part: you work because God is at work. Page 3 of the chart says it in one line: "You work because God is at work in you."

Word to know: sanctification. The Spirit's lifelong work of making you more like Christ. Stop 14 showed its once-for-all side; this is its growing side.

18 Baptism

a first step of following Jesus



ON THE CHART The small diamond on the violet line just after the cross, labeled "Baptism · Matt 28:19; Rom 6:4." It sits near the start of the line because it's one of the first steps after coming to Jesus.

IN PLAIN WORDS Jesus told his followers to baptize everyone who becomes his disciple. Baptism doesn't add anything to what Jesus did on the cross. It pictures it, and it marks you publicly as belonging to him and to his people. It's also one of the tools God uses to grow you (stop 19).

Matthew 28:18–20

> [18] Then Jesus came to them and said, "**All authority in heaven and on earth has been given to me.** [19] Therefore go and **make disciples** of all nations, **baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit**, [20] and **teaching them to obey everything I have commanded you**. And surely **I am with you always**, to the very end of the age."

WHAT TO NOTICE

- **Who commands it (verse 18).** Baptism isn't something the church made up. The risen Jesus commands it, with "all authority."
- **"In the name of."** Baptism marks you as belonging to the Father, the Son and the Holy Spirit: the same God who chose you, died for you and sealed you (Parts 1–3).
- **A beginning (verses 19–20).** "Baptizing them … and teaching them to obey." Baptism starts a life of learning to follow Jesus. That's why it sits at the start of the violet line.
- **"I am with you always."** The command ends with a promise.

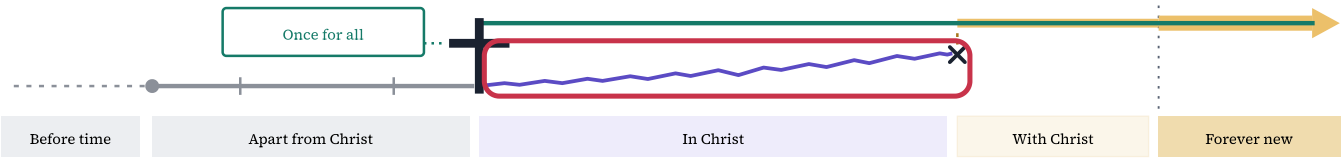
Romans 6:4 is printed at stop 12 (Romans 6:3–5): "We were therefore buried with him through baptism into death." Baptism pictures your union with Christ: down into the water with him in his death, and up out of it with him into a new life.

HOW THEY FIT TOGETHER Matthew 28 shows that Jesus commands baptism, and what it begins: a lifetime of following him. Romans 6 shows what it pictures: being joined to Jesus in his death and resurrection.

Word to know: baptism. Washing with water in the name of the Father, the Son and the Holy Spirit. It's a sign of being joined to Christ and to his people.

19 God's tools for growth

means of grace



ON THE CHART The words along the violet line: "Grows through God's Word, prayer, baptism and the Lord's Supper, and the church · Acts 2:41–42." Page 3 calls these "God's tools for growth."

IN PLAIN WORDS God grows you mainly through ordinary means he has given: his Word, prayer, baptism and the Lord's Supper, and life together in the church. They don't earn God's favor. They're the places where he has promised to meet you. A Christian who stays away from them is like a plant kept out of the sun.

Acts 2:41–42

> 41 Those who accepted his [Peter's] message **were baptized**, and about three thousand were added to their number that day. 42 They **devoted themselves to the apostles' teaching and to fellowship, to the breaking of bread and to prayer**.

WHAT TO NOTICE

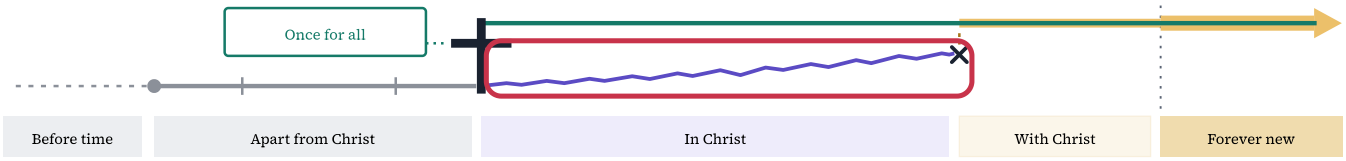
- **Who these people are.** About three thousand people who had just heard Peter preach the gospel and believed. This is the first week of their Christian lives.
- **"The apostles' teaching"** is God's Word. We have their teaching today in the New Testament.
- **"Fellowship"** is the church: believers sharing their lives with one another.
- **"The breaking of bread"** most likely includes the Lord's Supper, the meal Jesus gave his followers to remember his death.
- **"Prayer"** is talking with God, together and alone.
- **"Devoted themselves."** Not now and then, but as a steady habit.

HOW IT FITS THE CHART Notice the order in these two verses: they accepted the message, they were baptized, and then they devoted themselves to these four things. It's the order of the chart: turned to Jesus (stop 6), baptism (stop 18), and then growth along the violet line.

Word to know: means of grace. The ordinary tools God uses to grow his people: his Word, prayer, baptism and the Lord's Supper, and the church.

20 Putting sin to death

mortification



ON THE CHART Below the tools on the violet line: “Putting sin to death · Rom 8:13; Col 3:5–14.” Page 3 adds: “Daily turning from sin and putting on the new self.”

IN PLAIN WORDS Growth has two sides: saying no to sin and saying yes to Christlike ways. The Bible calls the first “putting sin to death.” You don’t do it by willpower alone; you do it “by the Spirit.” And you don’t only stop old habits. You put on new ones in their place.

Romans 8:13

> [13] For if you live according to the flesh, you will die; but **if by the Spirit you put to death the misdeeds of the body, you will live**.

WHAT THIS ADDS **The power for the fight.** “By the Spirit”: you do the fighting, but in his strength. The verse also gives a warning. A life that simply goes along with sin leads to death. “Flesh” here means the sinful desires still in you, not your physical body.

Colossians 3:5–10

> [5] **Put to death**, therefore, whatever belongs to your earthly nature: sexual immorality, impurity, lust, evil desires and greed, which is idolatry. [6] Because of these, the wrath of God is coming. [7] **You used to walk in these ways**, in the life you once lived. [8] But now you must also **rid yourselves** of all such things as these: anger, rage, malice, slander, and filthy language from your lips. [9] Do not lie to each other, since **you have taken off your old self** with its practices [10] and **have put on the new self, which is being renewed** in knowledge in the image of its Creator.

WHAT TO NOTICE

- **“Put to death, therefore.”** “Therefore” looks back to verses 1–4: you have died and been raised with Christ. Because of who you are (Part 3), you fight what you used to be.
- **“You used to walk in these ways” (verse 7).** Compare stop 16: the old self is who you were, not who you are.
- **“Have taken off … have put on” (verses 9–10).** That already happened. Now the new self is “being renewed” day by day. That’s the violet line again.

Colossians 3:12–14

> [12] Therefore, as **God’s chosen people, holy and dearly loved**, **clothe yourselves** with compassion, kindness, humility, gentleness and patience. [13] Bear with each other and forgive one another if any of you has a grievance against someone. **Forgive as the Lord forgave you.** [14] And over all these virtues **put on love**, which binds them all together in perfect unity.

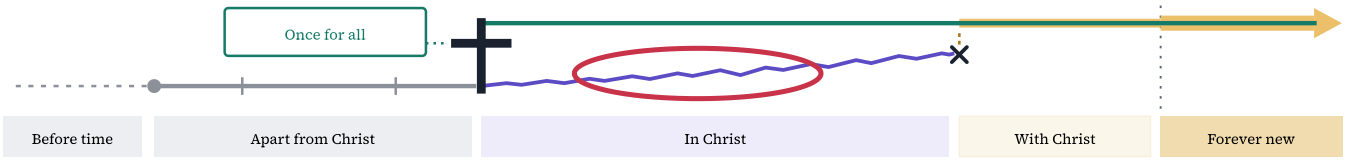
WHAT THIS ADDS **What to put on.** After the old clothes come off, Paul hands you new ones. Notice what he calls you first: “God’s chosen people, holy and dearly loved.” Who you are comes first, then what to do. (Verse 11, not printed here, says that in Christ, background and status no longer divide people.)

HOW THEY FIT TOGETHER Romans 8:13 gives the power: the Spirit. Colossians 3:5–10 says what to put off, and Colossians 3:12–14 says what to put on. Page 3 of the chart sums it up: "Daily turning from sin and putting on the new self."

Word to know: mortification. Putting sin to death: the daily work, in the Spirit's strength, of turning away from sin.

21 Still fighting sin

old desires, the world, the devil



ON THE CHART The dips in the violet line, labeled "Still fighting sin: Old desires, the world, the devil · Gal 5:17; 1 John 2:16; 1 Pet 5:8."

IN PLAIN WORDS Becoming a Christian doesn't end the fight with sin. In a way, it starts it. Before, you went along with sin. Now the Spirit in you resists it. The Bible names three enemies: your own old desires, the world around you, and the devil. The dips on the line are real, and they don't mean you were never saved.

Galatians 5:16–17

> [16] So I [Paul] say, **walk by the Spirit**, and you will not gratify the desires of the flesh. [17] For **the flesh desires what is contrary to the Spirit**, and the Spirit what is contrary to the flesh. **They are in conflict with each other**, so that you are not to do whatever you want.

WHAT THIS ADDS **Enemy 1: old desires, inside you.** "The flesh" means the sinful desires still in you. The conflict itself is a sign of life: a dead person feels no struggle. And verse 16 gives the way forward: walk by the Spirit.

1 John 2:15–17

> [15] **Do not love the world** or anything in the world. If anyone loves the world, love for the Father is not in them. [16] For everything in the world—**the lust of the flesh, the lust of the eyes, and the pride of life**—comes not from the Father but from the world. [17] **The world and its desires pass away**, but whoever does the will of God lives forever.

WHAT THIS ADDS **Enemy 2: the world, around you.** "The world" here doesn't mean people or creation; God loves the world (John 3:16). It means life arranged without God: wanting more, wanting what you see, wanting to look important. And verse 17 shows it doesn't last.

1 Peter 5:8–9

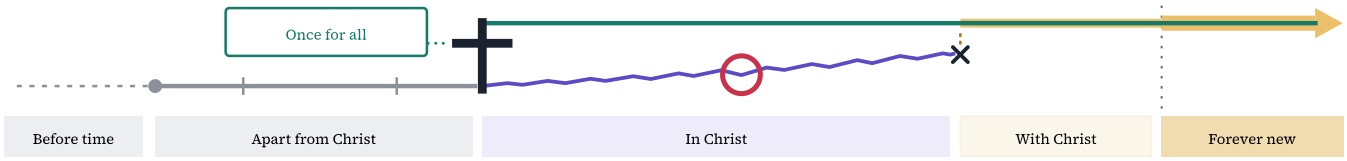
> [8] Be alert and of sober mind. **Your enemy the devil prowls around like a roaring lion** looking for someone to devour. [9] **Resist him, standing firm in the faith**, because you know that the family of believers throughout the world is undergoing the same kind of sufferings.

WHAT THIS ADDS **Enemy 3: the devil, against you.** He's real and dangerous, so stay alert. But he can be resisted. And you're not alone: believers around the world are in the same fight.

HOW THEY FIT TOGETHER Three enemies: one inside you, one around you, one against you. Each passage also shows how to stand: walk by the Spirit, do the will of God, resist the devil by standing firm in the faith.

22 When you fall, keep turning to Jesus

confession and restoration



ON THE CHART Below the dips: “When you fall. Keep turning to Jesus: confess, be restored · 1 John 1:9; Heb 12:10.” Page 3 adds: “You keep turning and trusting him every day.”

IN PLAIN WORDS You will fall. When you do, don’t run from God; run to him. The turning that began your Christian life (stop 6) goes on every day: turn from the sin, and trust Jesus again. Your standing hasn’t moved; the teal line stays level. So confessing isn’t asking to be saved again. It’s a child coming home to the Father.

> Acts 20:21 is printed at stop 6: “turn to God in repentance and have faith in our Lord Jesus.” That isn’t only how the Christian life starts. It’s how it continues.

1 John 1:8–9

> [8] **If we claim to be without sin, we deceive ourselves** and the truth is not in us. [9] **If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just and will forgive us our sins** and **purify us from all unrighteousness**.

WHAT TO NOTICE

- **“We.”** John is writing to believers, and he includes himself. Christians still sin. Pretending we don’t is the real danger.
- **“Faithful and just.”** Forgiveness isn’t God going easy on sin. It’s just, because Jesus already paid for it (stop 10).
- **“Forgive … and purify.”** God both forgives you and cleans you up.

Hebrews 12:10–11

> [10] They [our human fathers] disciplined us for a little while as they thought best; but **God disciplines us for our good, in order that we may share in his holiness**. [11] No discipline seems pleasant at the time, but painful. Later on, however, **it produces a harvest of righteousness and peace** for those who have been trained by it.

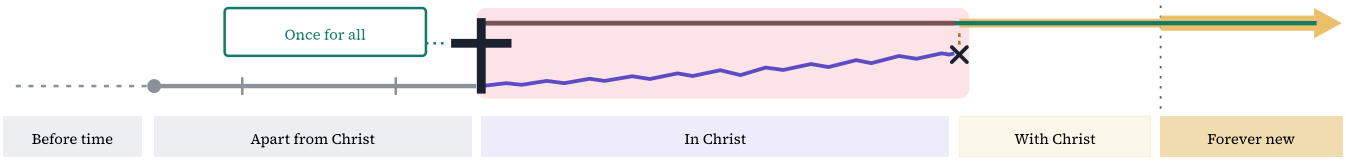
WHAT THIS ADDS **Why the road can be hard.** Sometimes God lets sin’s consequences sting, or allows hard things, to train us. This is discipline, not punishment; the punishment for your sin fell on Jesus at the cross. A father disciplines his own children, not strangers (verse 8). It hurts now and bears fruit later.

HOW THEY FIT TOGETHER 1 John 1:8–9 shows how you’re restored: confess, and God forgives and cleans. Hebrews 12:10–11 shows why the road can be hard: the Father is training his children for their good. Either way, the dip leads back up.

Word to know: confession. Agreeing with God about your sin, telling him plainly, and receiving his forgiveness.

23 Kept to the end

perseverance



ON THE CHART On the teal line: “Kept to the end · John 10:28–29.” Page 3 adds: “God keeps his people, and they keep trusting him. The line never falls back to the flatline.”

IN PLAIN WORDS Look at the lowest dips in the violet line: none of them drops back to the gray flatline. Everyone God truly saves, he keeps to the end. And he keeps them by keeping them trusting him. So perseverance has two sides, God’s keeping and your continuing. They don’t compete. The first is what makes the second happen.

John 10:27–29

> 27 My sheep listen to my voice; I [Jesus] know them, and **they follow me**. 28 I give them eternal life, and **they shall never perish; no one will snatch them out of my hand**. 29 My Father, who has given them to me, is **greater than all**; **no one can snatch them out of my Father’s hand**.

WHAT TO NOTICE

- **Two hands.** You are held in Jesus’ hand and in the Father’s hand. To take you away, someone would have to be stronger than God, and the Father is “greater than all.”
- **“They follow me.”** Following is the mark of Jesus’ sheep, not the price of staying in his hand.
- **“Never perish.”** Not “probably won’t.” Never.

Philippians 1:6

> 6 … being confident of this, that **he [God] who began a good work in you will carry it on to completion** until the day of Christ Jesus.

WHAT THIS ADDS **God finishes what he starts.** The “good work” is God’s work in you, the violet line. Paul is confident, not because the Philippians are strong, but because God is faithful. This verse comes back in Part 5, where the chart shows how God finishes the work.

Colossians 1:22–23

> 22 But now he [God] has reconciled you by Christ’s physical body through death **to present you holy in his sight, without blemish and free from accusation— 23 if you continue in your faith, established and firm**, and do not move from the hope held out in the gospel. This is the gospel that you heard and that has been proclaimed to every creature under heaven, and of which I, Paul, have become a servant.

WHAT THIS ADDS **Your side: true faith keeps going.** “If you continue” doesn’t make your standing shaky. It describes what real faith does: it lasts. Those whom God keeps, keep trusting him. And notice where the road ends: standing before God “without blemish.”

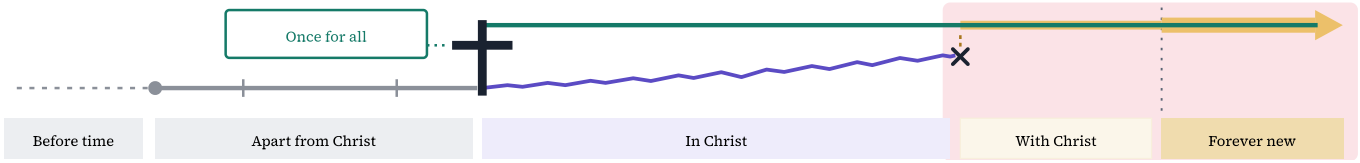
HOW THEY FIT TOGETHER John 10 and Philippians 1 show God’s side: no one can take you from him, and he will finish his work in you. Colossians 1 shows your side: real faith continues. The chart draws both. The teal line stays level, and the violet line never falls back to the flatline.

Word to know: perseverance. God keeping his people to the end, so that they keep trusting him to the end.

Part 5 follows the line to its end: death, Christ's return, and the life to come.

PART 5

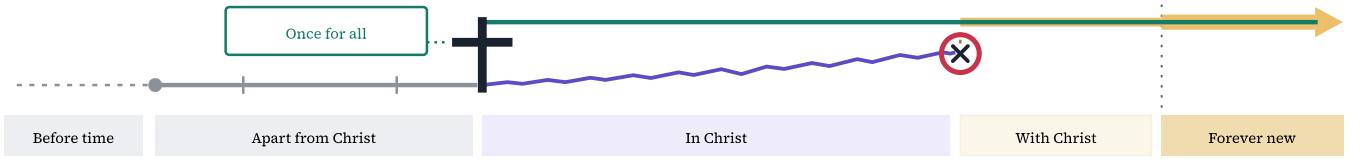
Death and the life to come



At the X, the violet line ends. For a believer, death isn't the end of the story. It's where God finishes his work in you and the gold begins. The gold band starts thin: your soul is with the Lord while your body rests. It turns thick when Christ returns: body and soul together again, and everything made new. And notice the teal line. It runs straight through death without a break. Your standing with God doesn't stop when your life here does.

24 Death

"to die is gain"



ON THE CHART The X at the end of the violet line, labeled "Death · 'To die is gain' · Phil 1:21; 1 Cor 15:55."

IN PLAIN WORDS Death is still real, and it still brings real grief. But for someone in Christ, it has lost its power to harm. It's the doorway to being with Jesus. That's why Paul can call it "gain."

Philippians 1:21–23

> 21 For to me, **to live is Christ and to die is gain**. 22 If I [Paul] am to go on living in the body, this will mean fruitful labor for me. Yet what shall I choose? I do not know! 23 I am torn between the two: I desire to **depart and be with Christ, which is better by far**; …

WHAT TO NOTICE

- **Where Paul is.** He wrote this letter in chains (verse 13), not knowing whether he would live or die (verse 20).
- **"To live is Christ."** Death is gain not because life is bad, but because it brings more of Christ. Life now is for him; death brings you to him.
- **"Depart and be with Christ."** No waiting room in between. To depart is to be with him.
- **"Better by far."** Not just a little better.

1 Corinthians 15:55–57

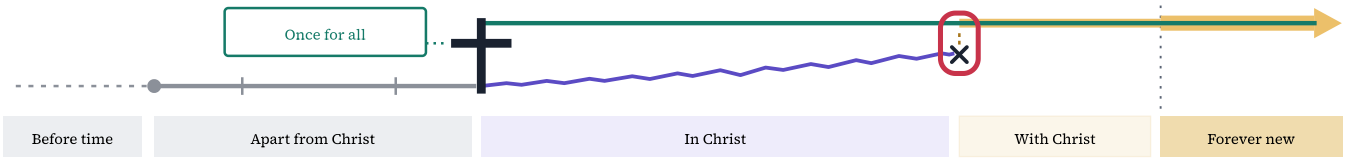
> 55 "Where, O death, is your victory?
> **Where, O death, is your sting?"**
> 56 **The sting of death is sin**, and the power of sin is the law. 57 But thanks be to God! **He gives us the victory through our Lord Jesus Christ.**

WHAT THIS ADDS **Why death can't harm you.** What makes death deadly is sin: it brings us to God's judgment guilty. But Jesus took your sin (stop 10). A bee that has lost its stinger can still frighten you, but it can't hurt you the way it once could. Death can still bring loss and tears, but for you its sting is gone.

HOW THEY FIT TOGETHER Philippians 1 shows why death is gain: it brings you to Christ. 1 Corinthians 15 shows why it's safe: Jesus pulled out its sting. Together they explain why the chart labels the X "To die is gain."

25 God closes the gap

made perfect at death



ON THE CHART The dashed gold arrow rising from the X to the gold band. Its label: "God closes the gap · '…will carry it on to completion' · Phil 1:6."

IN PLAIN WORDS Look at the chart: the violet line climbs all life long but never reaches the teal line. In this life, your growth never catches up with your standing. At death, God closes that gap in an instant. The moment you're with the Lord, you're completely free from sin. You don't get there by your own effort. God finishes what he started.

> **Philippians 1:6** is printed at stop 23: "he who began a good work in you will carry it on to completion." The dashed arrow is that completion.

Hebrews 12:22–24

> [22] But **you have come to Mount Zion, to the city of the living God**, the heavenly Jerusalem. You have come to thousands upon thousands of angels in joyful assembly, [23] to the church of the firstborn, whose names are written in heaven. You have come to God, the Judge of all, to **the spirits of the righteous made perfect**, [24] to **Jesus the mediator of a new covenant**, and to the sprinkled blood that speaks a better word than the blood of Abel.

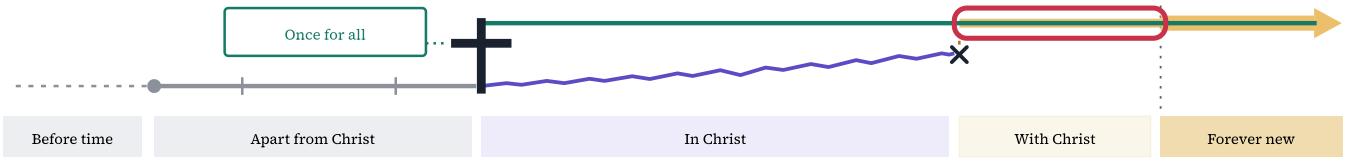
WHAT TO NOTICE

- **"The spirits of the righteous made perfect."** Believers who have died. "Spirits," because their bodies still wait for the resurrection. "Made perfect," because the gap is closed.
- **"You have come."** By faith you already belong to this gathering in heaven. When you die, you join it in person.
- **"Jesus the mediator."** Why sinners can stand before "God, the Judge of all": Jesus stands between, and his blood "speaks a better word." Abel's blood cried out for justice (Genesis 4:10); Jesus' blood speaks forgiveness.

HOW THEY FIT TOGETHER Philippians 1:6 is the promise: God will finish his work in you. Hebrews 12:23 shows the promise kept: believers who have died are "made perfect."

26 Glory begun

with Christ



ON THE CHART The thin gold band between death and Christ's return: "Glory begun · Free from sin, at home with the Lord · Heb 12:23; 2 Cor 5:8." The band along the bottom calls this season "With Christ: made perfect." Page 3 adds: "Your soul is made perfect and goes to be with Jesus, while your body rests."

IN PLAIN WORDS When a believer dies, their soul goes straight to be with Jesus. Their body is buried and rests, waiting for the resurrection. This is wonderful, but it isn't yet the end. Body and soul are still apart, and the world isn't yet made new. That's why the band is thin here.

2 Corinthians 5:6–8

> [6] Therefore we are always confident and know that as long as we are at home in the body we are away from the Lord. [7] For we live by faith, not by sight. [8] We are confident, I say, and would prefer to be **away from the body and at home with the Lord**.

WHAT THIS ADDS **Where the soul goes.** Paul names two places and no third. Here, "at home in the body," you live by faith, not by sight. There, "away from the body," you are "at home with the Lord." And he calls that a place to be confident about, not afraid of.

Philippians 1:23 is printed at stop 24: "I desire to depart and be with Christ, which is better by far."

1 Thessalonians 4:13–14

> [13] Brothers and sisters, we do not want you to be uninformed about those who sleep in death, so that **you do not grieve like the rest of mankind, who have no hope**. [14] For we believe that Jesus died and rose again, and so we believe that **God will bring with Jesus those who have fallen asleep in him**.

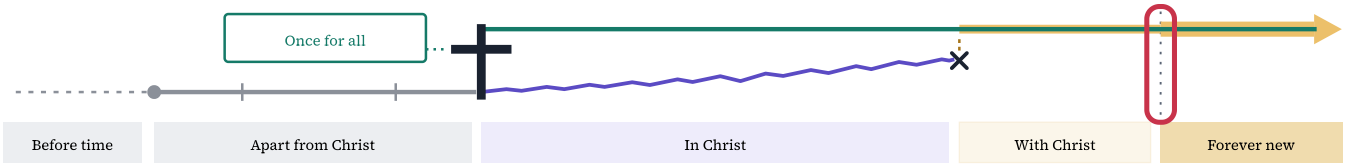
WHAT TO NOTICE

- **"Sleep."** A gentle word for a believer's death. Like sleep, death is real but not permanent: the body will wake up. It doesn't mean the person is unaware; Paul has already said that to be away from the body is to be at home with the Lord.
- **"Not … like the rest of mankind."** Christians do grieve. But they grieve with hope.
- **"Bring with Jesus."** When Jesus returns, those who have died in him come with him. They're with him now.

HOW THEY FIT TOGETHER 2 Corinthians 5 and Philippians 1 show where the soul goes: home with the Lord. 1 Thessalonians 4 shows what happens to the body: it rests until Jesus returns. That's "glory begun": the soul with Jesus, the body waiting.

27 Christ returns

the second coming



ON THE CHART The dotted line near the right edge: "Christ returns · 1 Thess 4:16–17." Page 3 adds: "Believers still alive when he comes will not die but be changed."

IN PLAIN WORDS One day Jesus will come back, in person and for everyone to see. Believers who have died will be raised, and believers still alive will be changed. Whether you died long ago or are alive that day, you end up in the same place: with the Lord forever. That's why the gold band turns thick at this line.

1 Thessalonians 4:16–18

> [16] For **the Lord himself will come down from heaven**, with a loud command, with the voice of the archangel and with the trumpet call of God, and **the dead in Christ will rise first**. [17] After that, we who are still alive and are left will be caught up together with them in the clouds to meet the Lord in the air. And so **we will be with the Lord forever**. [18] Therefore **encourage one another with these words**.

WHAT TO NOTICE

- **"The Lord himself."** Not a messenger. Jesus comes in person.
- **Loud and public.** A command, a voice, a trumpet. No one will miss it.
- **"Together with them."** Those who "fell asleep" (stop 26) rise first, and then all believers meet the Lord together. No one is left out.
- **"Encourage one another" (verse 18).** Paul gives this to comfort grieving believers, not to frighten them or to set dates.

1 Corinthians 15:51–52

> [51] Listen, I [Paul] tell you a mystery: We will not all sleep, but **we will all be changed**— [52] **in a flash, in the twinkling of an eye**, at the last trumpet. For the trumpet will sound, **the dead will be raised imperishable**, and we will be changed.

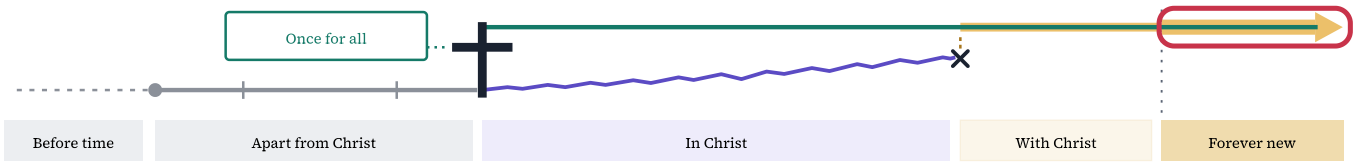
WHAT THIS ADDS **What happens to believers still alive.** A "mystery" in the Bible is something God kept hidden and has now made known. Here it is: some believers won't die at all. When Jesus returns, they'll be changed in an instant and receive the same new body as those who are raised.

HOW THEY FIT TOGETHER 1 Thessalonians 4 shows the order of that day: the dead rise, then the living join them. 1 Corinthians 15 shows how fast it happens: in the twinkling of an eye. Either way, every believer ends up with a new body, with the Lord forever.

Word to know: second coming. Jesus' return in person, for everyone to see, to raise the dead, judge the world and make all things new.

28 A new body

resurrection



ON THE CHART Under the thick gold band: "A new body like his glorious body · Phil 3:21; 1 Cor 15:52."

IN PLAIN WORDS God made you body and soul, and he doesn't plan to leave your body in the grave. He will raise it: still you, but made new. It will never get sick, grow old, die or sin again. The pattern is Jesus' own risen body.

Philippians 3:20–21

> [20] But **our citizenship is in heaven**. And we eagerly await a Savior from there, the Lord Jesus Christ, [21] who, by the power that enables him to bring everything under his control, **will transform our lowly bodies so that they will be like his glorious body**.

WHAT TO NOTICE

- **"We eagerly await a Savior from there."** The hope isn't only that we go to him, but that he comes to us.
- **"Our lowly bodies."** Bodies that get tired, sick and old. Jesus will transform them, not throw them away.
- **"Like his glorious body."** After he rose, Jesus could be touched and could eat, but he could never die again. Your new body will be like his.
- **"The power that enables him to bring everything under his control."** Raising the dead takes that kind of power, and Jesus has it.

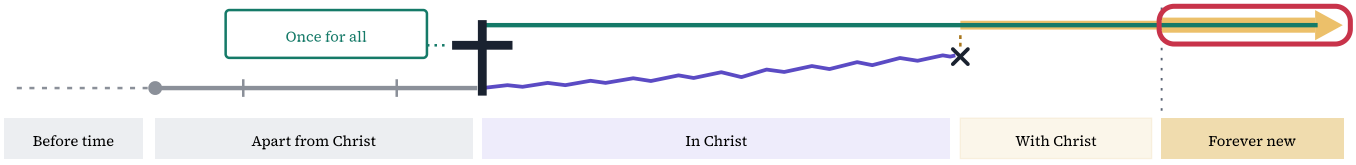
1 Corinthians 15:52 is printed at stop 27: "the dead will be raised imperishable, and we will be changed."

HOW THEY FIT TOGETHER Philippians 3:21 shows what the new body will be like: like Jesus' risen body. 1 Corinthians 15:52 shows when and how fast: at the last trumpet, in a flash. Romans 6:5 at stop 12 already promised it: "united with him in a resurrection like his."

Word to know: resurrection. God raising the dead body to new life that can never die. Jesus was raised first. His people will be raised when he returns.

29 Judgment and reward

standing before Christ



ON THE CHART Under the gold band: "Judgment and reward · 2 Cor 5:10."

IN PLAIN WORDS Everyone will stand before Jesus. For a believer, this isn't a trial to decide heaven or hell. That verdict was settled at the cross (stop 10). It's an accounting of how you lived, before a generous Lord who rewards. What you do with your life now matters forever.

2 Corinthians 5:10

> [10] For **we must all appear before the judgment seat of Christ**, so that each of us may **receive what is due us for the things done while in the body**, whether good or bad.

WHAT TO NOTICE

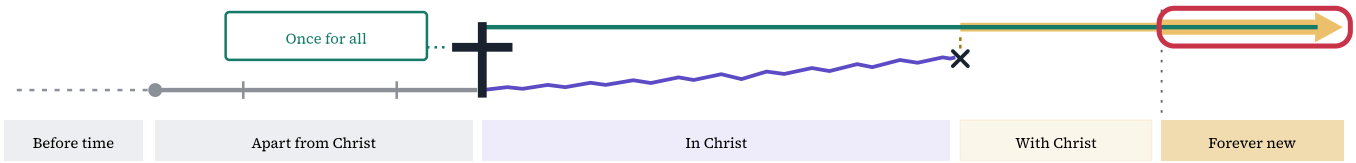
- **"We."** Paul includes himself and the believers he's writing to. Christians will stand there too.
- **"The judgment seat of Christ."** Jesus himself is the judge, the same Jesus who died for you.
- **"The things done while in the body."** Ordinary faithfulness, kindness and obedience in this life aren't wasted. God sees them.

Romans 8:1 is printed at stop 10: "there is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus."

HOW THEY FIT TOGETHER Romans 8:1 settles whether a believer will be condemned: no. 2 Corinthians 5:10 says a believer's life will still be weighed and rewarded. Both are true. You can't lose your place, and your life still matters to God.

30 New heavens, new earth

everything made new



ON THE CHART Under the gold band: "New heavens, new earth · Rev 21:1–5."

IN PLAIN WORDS The Bible's story doesn't end with souls floating away from the world. It ends with God making the world new and coming to live with his people. No more death, crying or pain.

Revelation 21:1–5

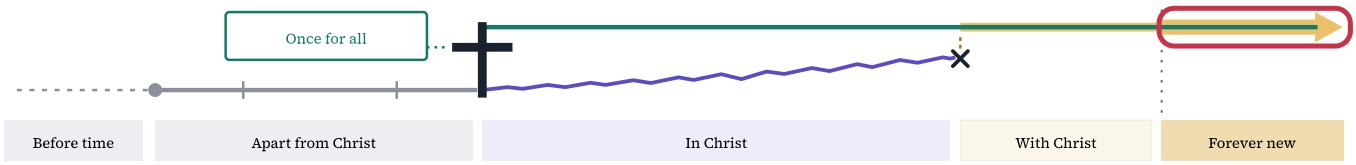
> [1] Then I [John] saw "**a new heaven and a new earth**," for the first heaven and the first earth had passed away, and there was no longer any sea. [2] I saw the Holy City, the new Jerusalem, coming down out of heaven from God, prepared as a bride beautifully dressed for her husband. [3] And I heard a loud voice from the throne saying, "Look! **God's dwelling place is now among the people**, and he will dwell with them. They will be his people, and **God himself will be with them** and be their God. [4] '**He will wipe every tear from their eyes. There will be no more death**' or mourning or crying or pain, for the old order of things has passed away." [5] He who was seated on the throne said, "**I am making everything new!**" Then he said, "Write this down, for these words are trustworthy and true."

WHAT TO NOTICE

- **Picture language.** John describes a vision with images like a city and a bride. The pictures point to something real that hasn't happened yet.
- **"No longer any sea."** In the Bible, the sea often stands for chaos and danger. Nothing threatening is left.
- **"God himself will be with them."** This is the heart of it. Since Eden, sin has kept people apart from God. Now God lives with his people for good.
- **"Making everything new."** Not making all new things, but making everything new. God renews the world he made.
- **"Trustworthy and true."** God has it written down so you can count on it.

31 “They will see his face”

with God forever



ON THE CHART The last words under the gold band: “‘They will see his face’ · Rev 22:4.”

IN PLAIN WORDS The best gift of the new creation isn’t a place. It’s a person. God’s people will see him face to face.

Revelation 22:3–5

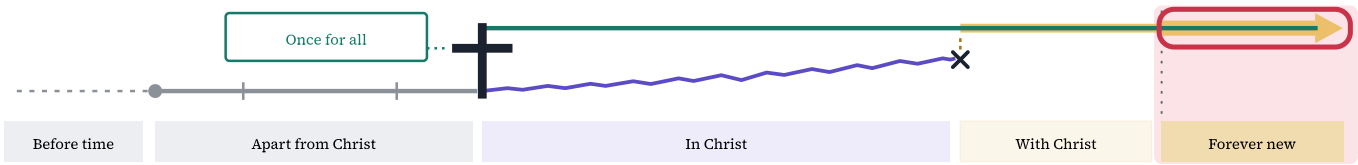
> [3] **No longer will there be any curse.** The throne of God and of the Lamb will be in the city, and his servants will serve him. [4] **They will see his face**, and **his name will be on their foreheads**. [5] There will be no more night. They will not need the light of a lamp or the light of the sun, for the Lord God will give them light. And **they will reign for ever and ever**.

WHAT TO NOTICE

- **“No longer … any curse.”** The curse came when sin entered the world (Genesis 3; see stop 2). Here it’s gone for good.
- **“God and … the Lamb.”** “The Lamb” is Jesus, the sacrifice for sin. He shares the throne with God.
- **“They will see his face.”** In the Old Testament, God told Moses, “No one may see me and live” (Exodus 33:20). Sin made it impossible. Now nothing stands in the way.
- **“His name … on their foreheads.”** They belong to him forever, like the Spirit’s seal (stop 13), but now for everyone to see.
- **“They will reign.”** Co-heirs with Christ (stop 11), sharing his rule.

32 Glory complete

glorification



ON THE CHART The thick gold band and its arrow at the far right: “Glory complete.” The band along the bottom calls this season “Forever new: saved from sin’s presence.” Page 3 adds: “Body and soul together again, raised like his glorious body, with all creation set free.”

IN PLAIN WORDS This is the end of the chart, and the last link in the chain of Romans 8:30 on page 1: “those he justified, he also glorified.” Body and soul together again, sin gone completely, and all creation set free. The arrow points off the page, because this part never ends.

Romans 8:18–23

> [18] I [Paul] consider that **our present sufferings are not worth comparing with the glory that will be revealed in us**. [19] For the creation waits in eager expectation for the children of God to be revealed. [20] For the creation was subjected to frustration, not by its own choice, but by the will of the one who subjected it, in hope [21] that **the creation itself will be liberated from its bondage to decay** and brought into the freedom and glory of the children of God. [22] We know that the whole creation has been groaning as in the pains of childbirth right up to the present time. [23] Not only so, but we ourselves, who have the firstfruits of the Spirit, groan inwardly as **we wait eagerly for our adoption to sonship, the redemption of our bodies**.

WHAT TO NOTICE

- **"Not worth comparing" (verse 18).** Paul suffered a great deal. He still says the glory to come outweighs all of it.
- **Creation is waiting too (verses 19–22).** When sin entered, the whole world was affected. When God's children are glorified, the world will be set free with them.
- **"Firstfruits of the Spirit."** The first part of the harvest, a promise of the rest. It's the same idea as the Spirit's "deposit" at stop 13.
- **"Adoption … the redemption of our bodies."** You're already God's child (stop 11). On that day, even your body will share in it.

Colossians 3:3–4

> [3] For you died, and **your life is now hidden with Christ in God**. [4] When Christ, who is your life, appears, then **you also will appear with him in glory**.

WHAT THIS ADDS **Hidden now, shown then.** Your new life is real now but hard to see, even for you. When Christ appears, it will be plain to everyone. Your glory is tied to his: when he appears, you appear with him.

> Philippians 3:21 is printed at stop 28: "will transform our lowly bodies so that they will be like his glorious body."

HOW THEY FIT TOGETHER Romans 8 shows how wide glory reaches: you and all creation. Colossians 3 shows its center: Christ. Philippians 3:21 shows that it includes your body. That's glory complete.

Word to know: glorification. God's final work of making his people perfect in body and soul, free from sin's presence forever. It begins for the soul at death and is completed when Christ returns.

LOOKING BACK OVER THE CHART

Three tenses of salvation

Page 3 of the chart sums up the whole timeline in three sentences. The Bible speaks of salvation in the past, present and future tense. Each one is true, and each one matches a different line on the chart.

ONCE FOR ALL

“I have been saved from sin’s penalty.”

Justification: secured at the cross, received by faith · the teal line

Romans 5:1

> [1] Therefore, since **we have been justified through faith**, **we have peace with God** through our Lord Jesus Christ, …

Romans 5:9

> [9] Since **we have now been justified by his blood**, how much more **shall we be saved from God’s wrath through him**!

WHAT THIS ADDS **Two tenses in one verse.** “Have now been justified” is the past. “Shall we be saved” is the future. The chart cites this verse in both rows, because the first makes the second certain.

Ephesians 2:8–9

> [8] For **it is by grace you have been saved, through faith**—and this is not from yourselves, **it is the gift of God**—
> [9] not by works, so that no one can boast.

EVERY DAY

“I am being saved from sin’s power.”

Sanctification, all of life · the violet line

1 Corinthians 1:18

> [18] For the message of the cross is foolishness to those who are perishing, but **to us who are being saved it is the power of God**.

Philippians 2:12–13 is printed at stop 17: “continue to work out your salvation … for it is God who works in you.”

FOREVER

“I will be saved from sin’s presence.”

Glorification, at the end · the gold band

Romans 13:11

> [11] And do this, understanding the present time: The hour has already come for you to wake up from your slumber, because **our salvation is nearer now than when we first believed**.

1 Peter 1:4–5

> [4] … and into **an inheritance that can never perish, spoil or fade**. This inheritance is kept in heaven for you, [5] who through faith are **shielded by God's power until the coming of the salvation that is ready to be revealed in the last time**.

> **Romans 5:9** is printed above, in the first tense: "how much more shall we be saved from God's wrath through him!"

HOW THEY FIT TOGETHER Keep the three tenses apart and many worries go away. When the Bible says you are "being saved," it isn't saying your standing is in doubt; it's talking about the violet line. When it says you "will be saved," it isn't saying you might not make it; it's talking about the gold. And when it says you "have been saved," that's the teal line, and it never changes.

For anyone not yet in Christ

The chart ends with a line for anyone reading it who hasn't yet turned to Jesus: "For anyone not yet in Christ, the flatline runs on to death and judgment (Heb 9:27). The invitation stands today: 'Whoever believes in the Son has eternal life' (John 3:36)."

Hebrews 9:27–28

> [27] Just as **people are destined to die once, and after that to face judgment**, [28] so **Christ was sacrificed once to take away the sins of many**; and he will appear a second time, not to bear sin, but **to bring salvation to those who are waiting for him**.

WHAT THIS ADDS **Two "onces."** Every person dies once and then faces judgment. But Christ died once, too, to take away sins. Everyone will meet him when he returns. The question is whether you'll meet him as your judge or as the Savior you've been waiting for.

John 3:36

> [36] **Whoever believes in the Son has eternal life**, but whoever rejects the Son will not see life, for God's wrath remains on them.

WHAT THIS ADDS **Two roads, and an open door.** "Has" is present tense: eternal life starts the moment you believe. And "whoever" leaves no one out.

WHAT TO DO Go back to stop 6. Turn from your sin to God, and put your trust in Jesus, who died and rose again for sinners. Tell him so in your own words. Then tell a Christian you trust, or a pastor, so they can help you take your next steps.

FOR REFERENCE

Words to know

Every key word in this guide, with the stop where it first appears.

Adoption stop 11

God's act of making you his child, with all the rights of a son or daughter in his family.

Baptism stop 18

Washing with water in the name of the Father, the Son and the Holy Spirit. It's a sign of being joined to Christ and to his people.

Confession stop 22

Agreeing with God about your sin, telling him plainly, and receiving his forgiveness.

Conviction stop 5

The Holy Spirit's work of showing you your sin and your need for Jesus.

Definitive sanctification stop 14

The once-for-all break with sin's rule when you are joined to Christ.

Effectual call stop 8

God's call through the gospel that actually brings a person to faith in Jesus.

Election stop 1

God's choice, made before time, to save his people in Christ. It's the "predestined" of Romans 8:30.

Faith stop 6

Trusting Jesus, relying on him and not on yourself to make you right with God.

Glorification stop 32

God's final work of making his people perfect in body and soul, free from sin's presence forever.

Gospel stop 4

"Good news." The message that Jesus, the Son of God, died for our sins and rose again, and that everyone who trusts him is forgiven and made new.

Justification stop 10

God declaring a sinner righteous, not because of anything they have done, but because of what Jesus did. It's received by faith.

Means of grace stop 19

The ordinary tools God uses to grow his people: his Word, prayer, baptism and the Lord's Supper, and the church.

Mortification stop 20

Putting sin to death: the daily work, in the Spirit's strength, of turning away from sin.

Perseverance stop 23

God keeping his people to the end, so that they keep trusting him to the end.

Regeneration stop 9

God's work of giving new spiritual life to a person. It's another word for being born again.

Repentance stop 6

Turning away from sin and toward God, a change of mind that shows up in a changed life.

Resurrection stop 28

God raising the dead body to new life that can never die. Jesus was raised first. His people will be raised when he returns.

Sanctification stop 17

The Spirit's lifelong work of making you more like Christ. Also called progressive sanctification.

Second coming stop 27

Jesus' return in person, for everyone to see, to raise the dead, judge the world and make all things new.

Sin stop 2

Turning away from God and his ways in what we think, say and do. It's also the condition of a heart that is turned away from him.

Union with Christ stop 12

Being joined to Jesus by faith, so that what is true of him becomes true of you.

FOR REFERENCE

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3:36 — not yet in Christ
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